

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THUS SPOKE SOCCERATES

India may figure nowhere on the global soccer map, but Prime Minister Narendra Modi doesn't discount the charm of the great game for diplomatic outreach. First, he used soccer to create a bond among BRICS nations. So what if India had the weakest team among the five emerging economies, he floated the idea of having a U-17 tournament. Two tourneys later, the plan lost steam. But soccer's still chasing our PM. Pablo Gonzalez, senator and chief of the state-owned oil giant Yacimientos Petrolíferos Fiscales in Argentina, the reigning world champion, recently gifted the PM a Messi T-shirt on the sidelines of the India Energy Week. A more diplomatic discourse could follow.

ANI



Snoop Alert

The spectre of electronic surveillance and phone tapping has returned to haunt Opposition leaders in Maharashtra. The Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) had booked a senior IPS official for allegedly tapping phones of Opposition leaders "illegally" during the BJP's previous stint in power. With the party back in the saddle, these fears have revived. **Ambadas Danve**, Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) member and leader of the Opposition in the legislative council, has asked senior functionaries in his Aurangabad district to use iPhones, which have a more secure operating system.

SACRILEGE BY ONE'S OWN

At Xavier University's convocation ceremony in Kolkata, where Chief Minister **Mamata Banerjee** was conferred a D.Litt., governor C.V. Ananda Bose compared her with John Milton, Winston Churchill, S. Radhakrishnan and A.B. Vajpayee, all renowned statesmen and also known for their literary pursuits. However, it was the comparison with poet-PM Vajpayee that riled the Bengal BJP. The saffron leaders could not fathom how someone cherry-picked by Union home minister Amit Shah and thought to be the prime minister's preferred bureaucrat do something like this. The Left is laughing out loud.



Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Jeemon Jacob, Prashant Srivastava, Dhaval Kulkarni and Romita Datta



Changing V-Cssitudes

Kanpur University vice-chancellor Professor **Vinay Kumar Pathak** rejoined office recently after two and a half months. He had gone incommunicado after an FIR was registered against him for bribery, corruption and extortion. The media cell of the university says the V-C was on medical leave. Pathak's return has come as a shock as the CM's office had wanted action against him. Opposition parties are now questioning the government's declared policy of zero tolerance against corruption and hinting at some sort of behind-the-door "settlement".

TREAT HIM RIGHT



An unusual fight has erupted in Kerala over former chief minister **Oommen Chandy**'s treatment for throat cancer, which the 79-year-old Congress leader was diagnosed with in 2019. His younger brother Alex and close associates alleged that he was being denied proper treatment. Former defence minister A.K. Antony, too, discussed the issue with his wife and son. Chandy himself defended his family in a Facebook video and said he was getting the best possible treatment in the country. Meanwhile, the Kerala government has instituted a six-member multi-disciplinary board to review the veteran Congressman's health.

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR